


GETTY IMAGES

**JASSI JAISA KOI NAHIN**
Bumrah in action against the Aussies in the 4th Test in Melbourne, Dec. 29, '24

cricket. No wonder India's premier pacer was nicknamed 'cheat-code' during the T20 World Cup. The joke goes that India was cheating because they got the full 20 overs to bat whilst the opposition only got 16, since Bumrah's four overs were as good as maidens. It was a similar story during the Test series Down Under where the contest was dubbed Australia vs Bumrah!

But whilst Bumrah's absolute best may have seemingly come in the last 12 months, his ascent to the summit began over half a decade ago. Sachin Tendulkar announced it in 2019, "He's already the best bowler in the world. And the best is yet to come." The prophecy didn't come as a surprise. It was Tendulkar, after all, who was first tasked with assessing the young man with an unorthodox technique. Brought to the Mumbai Indians' practice session by the franchise's head of scouting and former India coach, John Wright, in 2013, Bumrah was put through the 'Sachin test'. The nets session was over soon enough and the 19-year-old, all awkward action, raw speed and accuracy, had the master's nod of approval. The story of the same young man not making the main squad for the district Under-16 team a few years before then seemed like a lost chapter from history.

What impressed Tendulkar in the nets, the world witnessed a month later. Making his IPL debut against Royal Challengers Bangalore, Bumrah pocketed three wickets, including that of their captain and star bat, Virat Kohli. As a beleaguered Kohli walked back, LBW after failing to negotiate an in-swinger delivered from wide of the crease—making it an extremely awkward angle to read—a fielder at cover was watching closely. "I had played Bumrah in the Mumbai Indians nets. He was sharp and awkward to face. I knew he would get Virat out the moment he lands one good ball," former India player Ambati Rayudu told INDIA TODAY. "And when it happened, you could see the shock on Virat's face. For him, it was a big surprise, but we knew it was coming."

One could argue that what happened to Kohli that summer night in Bengaluru had an element of surprise. But what explains the Ahmedabad-born speedster tormenting batters year after year in this age of endless video analysis where it's impossible to keep novelty and surprise alive? Former Test cricketer Mohammed Kaif has an explanation for what he sees as Bumrah's secret sauce. "Many bowlers in the past have had incredible skill and pace, what sets Jasprit apart is his talent for formulating a pinpoint plan [against batters] and then executing it instantly," he says.

But for all these moving parts to come together, another quality has been integral in the making of the Bumrah legend—his groundedness. Match highlight reels are peppered with examples of Boom Boom's immaculate on-field conduct: his measured celebrations and gentlemanly demeanour. Away from the cameras, Bumrah remains the model cricketer. Anyone who's involved with the game or has come in contact with the speedster would attest to this. This writer saw this first-hand during the 2024 T20 World Cup where some of Bumrah's teammates were staying separately in hotels of their choice with personal chefs, social media crews and even personal security. Meanwhile, In-

## MILESTONES-2024

- **ICC's CRICKETER OF THE YEAR and also TEST CRICKETER OF THE YEAR**
- **PLAYER OF THE TOURNAMENT in the 2024 T20 World Cup**
- **MAN OF THE SERIES**
  **India vs Australia Border-Gavaskar trophy Test series**